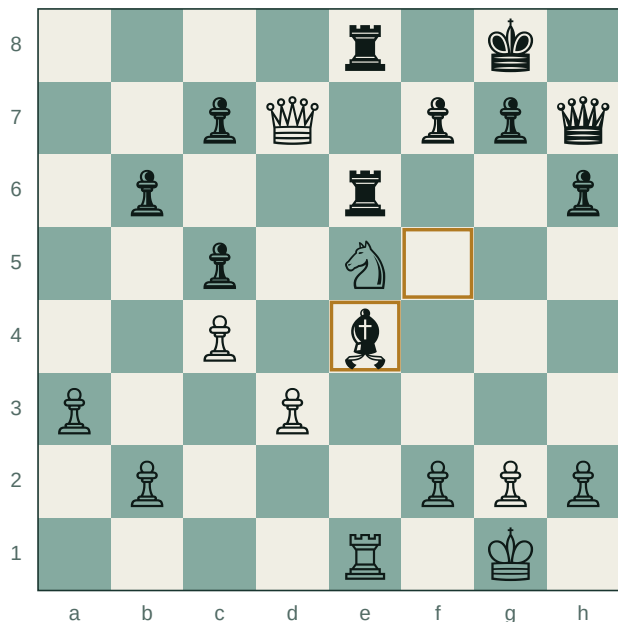


Intermediate moves: White, move 26

Intermediate moves

White to move



Previous move: 25...Bxe4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

26. Qxf7+ Kh8 27. Rxe4 Qxe4 28. dxe4

26.Qxf7+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. From f7 it attacks king on g8, rook on e8 and rook on e6. Recorded reply: **26...Kh8**.

27.Rxe4 The rook captures the bishop on e4. Recorded reply: **27...Qxe4**.

28.dxe4 The pawn captures the queen on e4.

At the end, nominal material is White 19 / Black 15 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +8. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +8: the balance goes from -4 to +4. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

The postponed recapture may disappear. The intermediate move must win enough or preserve the right to recover material.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An intermediate move interrupts an expected sequence with a stronger immediate threat. Instead of recapturing automatically, use a check or another forcing move to change the result.

HOW TO LOOK

Before every routine recapture, scan checks, queen attacks, and mating threats. Return to the original capture only if it still helps.

The defending king is on g8. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.